despotism was in no way also an experience of alien rule.

In India, before the British colonial empire came into existence, there was no consciousness of Indian versus foreign rule, although in several parts of the country there may have been local revolts against the Muslim rulers, or earlier against invaders from the north and the west. It is only in the nineteenth century that a specifically Indian national consciousness began to emerge and a political struggle against colonial rule gathered momentum.

There are more recent shifts in the Chinese historical narrative which serve a political purpose. The Taiwanese leader Chiang Kai-shek was a much-reviled figure in communist China, being presented as ‘a running dog of American imperialism’ and as a traitor to the great cause of the Chinese people. His role in China’s bloody war with Japan was completely obliterated. China’s victory over Japan was credited solely to communist forces led by Mao Zedong. However, in recent years, Chiang Kai-shek has undergone a complete makeover in China. He is now presented as a patriot and as a determined warrior against Japanese aggression. This change was first noticed during the celebration of the sixtieth anniversary of China’s victory over Japan in 2009, when Chiang was for the first time presented as a patriot, if a misguided one. This was further reinforced during the seventieth anniversary celebrations in 2015. Yang Tianshi of the Chinese Institute of Modern History wrote: ‘Chiang Kai-shek never wavered in his determination to resist the Japanese. He was a nationalist and a patriot.’ [3]

There are few instances of such total historical revisionism elsewhere in the world. The fact that Chiang had always opposed the independence of Taiwan and looked to a future of reunification with China is a plus point, although that unification would have taken place under a political dispensation very different from China’s one-party communist state.

By the same token, Chiang is now being presented as one of the architects of the post-Second World War international order, one of the victorious Allies, and a founding member of the United Nations. The fact that the China which played that role was Chiang’s Republic of China (ROC) government has been passed over. That the ROC occupied the United Nations Security Council seat was constantly denounced by the PRC. In